14 More Than Just a Pretty Vase: How Kerameikos.org Makes Studying Greek Pottery Accessible, Connected, and Collaborative through Linked Open Data

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Kerameikos.org is an international Digital Humanities project defining the intellectual concepts of Greek figure-decorated pottery following the tenets of Linked Open Data (LOD). The project provides reliable, streamlined definitions written and translated by humans into multiple languages for core concepts including shapes, techniques, artists, places, and periods. Our controlled vocabulary presents users with simple yet accurate definitions, and the LOD framework it supports connects concepts with thousands of associated objects from institutions adhering to Open Data principles.

Kerameikos.org democratizes Greek vases as data. It merges information across systems and cultural sectors and represents museum-quality objects and excavation pottery as equal. Additionally, the open digital access facilitated by Kerameikos.org allows information to be freely available, bringing to the forefront questions of equity, impact, and ease of access. The project redirects perceptions of Greek vases away from “objets d’art” to dynamic data points that can be analyzed and reconfigured in infinite ways.

The primary goals of Kerameikos.org are to make the study of Greek figure-decorated pottery more accessible, connected, and collaborative. We adhere to FAIR principals, partner with cultural heritage institutions, and work with an international team in researching, writing, editing, and translating content. By harnessing the potential of LOD and adhering to FAIR principles, Kerameikos.org attempts to place Greek vases more readily into the public eye and more open to global connection and engagement. The paper demonstrates how Kerameikos.org strives towards a future for Greek vases, and for pottery studies in general, that is both linked and open; and one where stakeholders can access reliable information that adheres to the ethics and protocols that underlie best practices in the Digital Humanities and to the rigors of archaeology as a data-driven discipline.